This Moroccan bean and lentil soup is a meal in a bowl often eaten for breakfast during Ramadan, to keep people going right through a day of fasting.

harira

SERVES 6–8 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 1 HR 5 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

1 large onion, chopped
2 tbsp olive oil
10oz–1lb 2oz (300–500g) shoulder of lamb on the bone
1 tsp ground ginger
1 tsp ground cinnamon
leaves of 1 small bunch parsley, finely chopped
leaves of 1 small bunch cilantro, finely chopped
5½oz (150g) brown lentils, rinsed
1 x 14oz (400g) can chopped tomatoes
2 tbsp tomato purée
salt and freshly ground black pepper
3½oz (100g) vermicelli noodles
1 x 14oz (400g) can chickpeas, drained, or 14oz (400g) cooked chickpeas
3 tbsp flour
lemon wedges, to serve

1 Cook the onion gently in the oil until translucent. While it cooks, cut the meat from the lamb bones in 1¼in (3cm) cubes. Reserve the bones.

2 Once the onions are tender, stir in the ginger, cinnamon, half the parsley, and half the cilantro, then add the lamb chunks and bone and turn to coat evenly. Now add the lentils, tomatoes, and tomato purée and season with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Mix well and simmer for a few minutes, then add 1¾ quarts (1¾ liters) of water. Let simmer for 45 minutes, then remove the lamb bones and add the vermicelli and chickpeas.

3 Put the flour in a small bowl with a ladleful of the cooking liquid and stir to make a smooth paste the consistency of thick cream, adding more liquid if needed. Stir this back into the soup and simmer for another 3–4 minutes until it has thickened and the vermicelli is cooked.

4 Just before serving, stir in the remaining herbs, and adjust the seasoning. Serve with wedges of lemon.